From Ottawa I called my friends and contacts in Toronto, and from Los Angeles my contacts in San Francisco, Yuba City and Sacramento areas. I met my friends, contacts and relatives wherever I went. The story was somewhat similar everywhere. Rather than being repetitive, I shall sum up my impressions of the visit towards the end of this chapter.

In Ottawa, I met some of my old Sikh friends and contacts, in addition to calling on Indian High Commissioner Gurdial Singh Dhillon, former speaker of the Lok Sabha and later minister for agriculture in Rajiv Gandhi's cabinet, at his residence. He was an old colleague of my father-in-law's and was aware of my background. Dhillon told me that developments back home were having a serious impact on the traditionally cordial relations between the Sikh and Hindu Indian immigrants settled in the country. Gurudwaras in Canada, specially from the Toronto and Vancouver areas, were becoming centres of Sikh religious orthodoxy and propaganda against the Government of India.

My friends and contacts whom I met separately also endorsed Dhillon's views, though they said that Ottawa had so far remained comparatively immune to such influences. But some of their Sikh and Hindu friends were getting confused as to what was happening in Punjab and why the ruling party (Congress) was so tolerant of Bhindranwale-led or sponsored activities. I also contacted a couple of friends from Toronto by phone. There the situation appeared to have changed significantly since I left Canada towards the end of 1979. In addition to religious activities, gurudwaras were also becoming centres of political discussions reflective of what was happening in Punjab.

It was in Vancouver that I had maximum exposure to influential members of the local Sikh community. It was the Christmas holiday season. My host and his friends were thrilled to discover that my Canadian driving licence was still valid and that I held a diplomatic passport. Over and above that I was a teetotaller. It was a godsend to them. Earlier, one of them had to abstain from drinking to drive the car, but now, with me as driver, my host and his friends could all drink as much as they wished. It being the Christmas season, we started party hopping, which gave me an opportunity to meet a large